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From the editor-in-chief

In March 2008, I was in Pakistan to attend a wedding and used the occasion to ask for a meeting with Nawaz Sharif, then flush with the sterling performance of his Pakistan Muslim League (PML-N) in the February parliamentary elections. We met for an early breakfast at his sprawling estate outside Lahore which is dotted with palatial houses. He exuded the confidence of a man who would rule Pakistan soon and he seemed to be in no hurry. He was happy that democracy had been restored in Pakistan. Although his party had joined the PPP-led coalition Government, one could see that the relationship was a prickly one. He refrained from saying anything against Asif Zardari, husband of assassinated leader Benazir Bhutto, but said he had a simple two-point agenda: remove Musharraf and restore deposed Supreme Court Chief Justice Iftikhar Chaudhry. Well, by last week he has, by default or otherwise, achieved both his objectives.

The political crisis in Pakistan was another reminder of how fragile the country's fledgling democracy is. For a while, political analysts were predicting a return to martial law. General Ashfaq Kayani, the army chief, showed better judgement than his predecessors in playing a diplomatically astute role and bringing the snowballing crisis under control rather than letting it descend into violence and getting a neat justification to take over.

Last week's events have resulted in Sharif emerging as the clear winner and reinforcing his claim to being the most popular political leader in the country. The thousands who took to the streets in Pakistan to support his Long March, defy the Government and press to restore the Supreme Court judges showed his clout is not just restricted to his power base of Punjab. The biggest loser is President Zardari who was forced to compromise. Many people in Pakistan see him as an usurper, not a legitimate political leader. For a while he had the upper hand but miscalculated by imposing governor's rule in Punjab. After that, the more Zardari tried to assert his authority over the country and Prime Minister Yousaf Gilani, the deeper he sank into the quagmire. It was fertile ground for Sharif to extract sweet revenge and propel himself to centrestage.

The power shift has major implications for Pakistan, and India. The defusing of the crisis was greeted with relief in New Delhi but worries remain. Sharif has emerged stronger but so has Gilani, leading to a volatile situation. Zardari, humiliated, will be desperate to reassert his authority. The economy is in a mess, extremist violence is on the rise, the army is battling the Taliban and it is not clear how long the current political reconciliation will last. What will be the army's role and how will Sharif leverage his resurgence? Our Pakistan contributor Hasan Zaidi decodes what the power shift means while Managing Editor Raj Chengappa spoke to Sharif on the phone for an exclusive interview. Senior Editor Saurabh Shukla looks at the implications of all this instability for India.

Pakistan is often referred to as a 'bonsai democracy': Sadly, time and time again, it lives up to this reputation. Having just pulled back from the brink, hopefully the politicians will now reconcile their differences and let democracy grow into a full tree with deep roots.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR MARCH 2008 COVER